

60 YEARS OF FREEDOM

URBAN TRANSPORT
DELHI



Life in a Metro

Its underground hum, cloaked in South Korean-built sleekness, mirrors a city's gradual transformation from an urban sprawl to a global metropolis

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It's 40 minutes past five at the close of a weekday at Delhi's Rajiv Chowk—the heart of the Delhi Metro under Connaught Place. Counters beep and the tiny gates furiously spit commuters into the sprawling concrete concourse under a giant skydome. This could be a tube scene in London, New York or anywhere in the world, right down to the banks of flat-screen television with the looped public service alerts of global terror strikes. Passengers are asked to report suspicious activity to the dozens of assault-rifle toting Central Industrial Security Force personnel who took over the Metro after the London underground strikes. The pat-down security checks and luggage inspections could do an airline proud and are now part of Metro life. Bright blue and silver aluminium coaches

slide into the station as thousands of middle-aged working women, college students and sweaty traders wade into the air-conditioned comfort of the train. They don't wait for passengers to alight, of course. That, like the art of neatly folding a newspaper broadsheet to readable proportions which a Mumbaikar excels in, is a trait ingrained in you after generations of train travel.

The route, which runs the 28-km distance to the south-western suburb of Dwarka, close to the airport, is only two years old. An infant, when compared to the hoary Raj-era cattle cars of Mumbai or Kolkata's truncated, labourious, 1980s-era communist Metro. The awe-struck faces, now reserved for gawkers from out of town, have given way to the vacant, business-as-usual faces of the global traveller. As are the sleek white insides of the South Korean-built coaches with digital crawlers on

RUSH HOUR:
A day at the
busy Delhi
Metro station

